

Amutheezan Sivagnanam

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SUMMARY

PhD Candidate and **Machine Learning Researcher** specializing in **Deep Reinforcement Learning** with **six** years of academic research and **two** years of industrial software development experience. Expertise in **scalable deep learning and reinforcement learning systems**, **ML training, and deployment**, complemented by a **strong publication record (h-index 6)**. Proficient in **Python, TensorFlow, PyTorch**, **AWS**, and agile **CI/CD** practices, with hands-on experience in **optimizing ML models and pipelines**.

EDUCATION

Pennsylvania State University

Ph.D., Computer Science — *Aug 2025*

Dissertation: *Application of Deep Reinforcement Learning to Solve Optimization Problems in Transportation Domains*

University of Houston

M.S., Computer Science — *Aug 2022*

University of Moratuwa

B.S., (Hons) Engineering (Computer Science and Engineering) — *Jan 2018*

Final Year Project: *Sentimental Analysis of Twitter using Semi-Supervised Approaches*

AREAS OF EXPERTISE

Reinforcement Learning, Optimization, Operational Research

SKILLS

Programming Languages: Python, C++, Java, C, JavaScript, PHP, MATLAB

Frameworks & Libraries: PyTorch, TensorFlow, Scikit-learn, Ray, RLlib, OpenAI Gym, NumPy, pandas, matplotlib, CPLEX, Gurobi, Mosek, OR-Tools

Databases: SQL, MySQL, SQLite, MongoDB

Tools & Platforms: Amazon Web Services, Git, GitHub, Linux, Docker, Spark, CI/CD, Bash

Methodologies: Object-Oriented Development, Agile, Behaviour Driven Development

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Pennsylvania State University — Graduate Research Assistant

Applied Artificial Intelligence Lab

Aug. 2022 - May 2025

- Spearheaded research projects funded by the U.S. Department of Energy (DOE) and the National Science Foundation (NSF), leading to advancements in cost and energy-efficient technologies
- Studied real-world decision-making problems and identified gaps in existing solution approaches, leading to the development of innovative strategies for improved decision-making
- Developed mathematical models and formulated problems to address these challenges, resulting in more accurate predictions and solutions for complex issues
- Applied artificial intelligence-based solutions to tackle real-world problems and successfully deployed them in relevant industries
- Published research findings in AI conferences (ICML) and assisted in preparing slides for presenting results at DOE and NSF meetings
- Developed a deep reinforcement learning (DRL) method (using DDPG) for proactive responder repositioning in emergency management, achieving significantly faster response times while reducing operational delays
- Applied DRL (using DQN) to solve online vehicle routing with advance booking, enabling real-time confirmations within seconds

The University of Houston — Graduate Research Assistant

Resilient Networks and Systems Lab

Sep. 2019 - Aug. 2022

- Spearheaded research projects funded by the U.S. Department of Energy (DOE) and the National Science Foundation (NSF), leading to advancements in energy-efficient technologies
- Studied real-world decision-making problems and identified gaps in existing solution approaches, leading to the development of novel methodologies for enhanced decision-making
- Developed mathematical models and formulated problem statements to effectively address these challenges, resulting in more accurate predictions and solutions for complex issues
- Applied AI-based solution approaches to real-world problems and successfully deployed them in relevant industries
- Published research findings in AI conferences (AAAI, IJCAI) and assisted preparing slides for presenting results at DOE and NSF meetings
- Introduced heuristics that reduced annual energy costs by \$140K for public transit agencies operating mixed fleets of buses

- Implemented a deep reinforcement learning (using DQN) approach that reduced operational costs by 20% by enabling online booking for traditionally offline Vehicle Routing Problems (VRPs)
- Collected and analyzed real-world data using Python to identify trends—such as changes in paratransit operations before and after COVID-19 and the impact of vulnerability reward programs

SOFTWARE ENGINEERING EXPERIENCE

LSEG Technology — Software Engineer

Post Trade Team

Jan 2018 – Jul 2019

- Developed application software using Object-Oriented principles, enhancing code maintainability and scalability
- Implemented agile development practices, such as Scrum, to improve team collaboration and project delivery speed
- Developed software solutions using Java, Python, and C++, improving system performance and reliability
- Introduce Unit Testing for Libraries in Post Trade C++ Code
- Modified database structures and tested using BDD-based testing, ensuring data integrity and system functionality
- Identified and replaced duplicated error codes with valid new error codes, improving system reliability
- Developed a dynamic scripting object (DSO) for front-end end-to-end testing using Java, enhancing test coverage and efficiency
- Analyzed and modified back-end regression scripts to work with both old and new testing frameworks, ensuring compatibility and reducing testing time
- Developed a new report generation system for the testing framework, automating email dispatch at the end of regression and improving communication efficiency
- Completed code integration tasks related to back-end regression, streamlining the development process and enhancing system performance
- Updated automatic updates to auto-generated codes based on Database changes using Integration Plans
- Contributed to code integration and deployment plans, ensuring seamless software updates and minimizing downtime
- Participated in professional training programs conducted by Millennium IT Software and Post Trade Team
- Worked on Front-End Development for both Product and Solution which consists of Enhancement, Bug Fixing, Merging and Introducing new features

WSO2 Lanka PVT Ltd — Software Engineering Intern

Data Analytics Team

Jul 2016 – Dec 2016

- Developed an alert generation system analyzing descriptive HL7/FHIR data to monitor disease outbreaks, triggering timely email and SMS notifications
- Engineered a mechanism to evaluate hospital functionality by assessing admission and discharge messages, including bed and oxygen cylinder availability

PUBLICATIONS

CONFERENCE PROCEEDINGS

[C7] **Sivagnanam, A.**, Pettet, A., Lee, H., Mukhopadhyay, A., Dubey, A., & Laszka, A. (2024). Multi-agent reinforcement learning with hierarchical coordination for emergency responder stationing. In *Proceedings of the International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML-24)*.

[C6] R. Sen, **A. Sivagnanam**, A. Laszka, A. Mukhopadhyay and A. Dubey, "Grid-Aware Charging and Operational Optimization for Mixed-Fleet Public Transit," *2024 IEEE 27th International Conference on Intelligent Transportation Systems (ITSC)*, Edmonton, AB, Canada, 2024, pp. 4172-4179,

[C5] Pavia, S., Rogers, D., **Sivagnanam, A.**, Wilbur, M., Edirimanna, D., Kim, Y., Mukhopadhyay, A., Pugliese, P., Samaranayake, S., Laszka, A., & Dubey, A. (2024). SmartTransit.AI: A dynamic paratransit and microtransit application. In *Proceedings of the Thirty-Third International Joint Conference on Artificial Intelligence (IJCAI-24)* (pp. 8767–8770).

[C4] Atefi, S., **Sivagnanam, A.**, Ayman, A., Grossklags, J., & Laszka, A. (2023, May). The benefits of vulnerability discovery and bug bounty programs: Case studies of Chromium and Firefox. In *Proceedings of the ACM Web Conference* (pp. 2209–2219).

[C3] **Sivagnanam, A.**, Kadir, S. U., Mukhopadhyay, A., Pugliese, P., Dubey, A., Samaranayake, S., & Laszka, A. (2022, July). Offline vehicle routing problem with online bookings: A novel problem formulation with applications to paratransit. In *Proceedings of the Thirty-First International Joint Conference on Artificial Intelligence (IJCAI-22)* (pp. 3933–3939).

[C2] **Sivagnanam, A.**, Ayman, A., Wilbur, M., Pugliese, P., Dubey, A., & Laszka, A. (2021, May). Minimizing energy use of mixed-fleet public transit for fixed-route service. In *Proceedings of the AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence (Vol. 35, No. 17, pp. 14930–14938)*.

[C1] Ayman, A., Wilbur, M., **Sivagnanam, A.**, Pugliese, P., Dubey, A., & Laszka, A. (2020, September). *Data-driven prediction of route-level energy use for mixed-vehicle transit fleets*.

In Proceedings of the 6th IEEE International Conference on Smart Computing (SMARTCOMP) (pp. 1–8). IEEE.

JOURNALS

[J2] Wilbur, M., Ayman, A., **Sivagnanam, A.**, Ouyang, A., Poon, V., Kabir, R., Vadali, A., Pugliese, P., Freudberg, D., Laszka, A., & Dubey, A. (2023). Impact of COVID-19 on Public Transit Accessibility and Ridership. *Transportation Research Record*, 2677(4), 531-546.

[J1] Ayman, A., **Sivagnanam, A.**, Wilbur, M., Pugliese, P., Dubey, A., & Laszka, A. (2022). Data-driven prediction and optimization of energy use for transit fleets of electric and ICE vehicles. *ACM Transactions on Internet Technology*, 22(1), Article 7, 1–29

WORKSHOPS

[W1] **Sivagnanam, A.**, Atefi, S., Ayman, A., Grossklags, J., & Laszka, A. (2021). On the benefits of bug bounty programs: A study of Chromium vulnerabilities. In *Workshop on the Economics of Information Security (WEIS)* (Vol. 10).

BOOK CHAPTERS

[BC1] Wilbur, M., **Sivagnanam, A.**, Ayman, A., Samaranayake, S., Dubey, A., & Laszka, A. (2023, August). Artificial intelligence for smart transportation. In **Y. Vorobeychik & A. Mukhopadhyay (Eds.)**, *Artificial Intelligence and Society* (book chapter). ACM Press.

TALKS

IJCAI 2022

Vienna, Austria

For the paper: Offline Vehicle Routing Problem with Online Bookings:
A Novel Problem Formulation with Applications to Paratransit

WEIS 2021

Virtual Workshop

For the workshop paper: On the Benefits of Bug Bounty Programs:
A Study of Chromium Vulnerabilities

AAAI 2021

Virtual Conference

For the paper: Minimizing Energy Use of Mixed-Fleet Public Transit
for Fixed-Route Service

SERVICES

Program Committee Member

International Joint Conference on Artificial Intelligence (AI For Social Good) 2025

Reviewer

International Joint Conference on Artificial Intelligence (AI For Social Good) 2024

Reviewer

AI4Research Workshop @IJCAI2024
2024

Auxiliary Reviewer

22nd International Conference on Autonomous Agents and Multiagent Systems
2023

AWARDS AND HONORS**Information Security Quiz 2015 - Runners Up**

2015

Issued by Sri Lanka Computer Emergency Readiness Team(SLCERT)
and Information and Communication Technology Agency of Sri Lanka(ICTA)

Mahapola Scholarship

2014 - 2017